

- CSO approval: 27/05/2022
- Start date: 22/09/2022

## 1 ATTENDANCE

### MC Members:

Christian Baden (Chair), Edlira Gugu (AL), Fabienne Lind (AT), Tamara Kunic (HR), Lenka Vochocova (CZ), Srdjan Vesic (FR), Gabriella Szabo (HU), Neta Kligler Vilenchik (IL), Asta Zelenkauskaitė (LT), Larissa Mistrean (MD), Damian Trilling (NL), Agnieszka Hess (PL), Agnieszka Stepinska (PL), Aleksandra Krstic (SR), Ilia Tomanic Triundzva (SI), Carlos Arcila Calderon (ES), Aleksandra Urman (CH); Mario Haim (DE, via Zoom), Nicoleta Corbu (RO, via Zoom); Peter Maurer (SE, incoming MC Member, not yet formally confirmed)

### Guests:

Carlos Cunha (WG1 Vice Chair), Johannes B. Gruber (WG2 Chair), Ana Milojevic (Science Communication Officer), Kasper Welbers (Grant Holder Scientific Representative, via Zoom), Nina Springer (Grant Coordination Officer, via Zoom)

### 17 MC member countries represented + 1 informally represented:

Albania, Austria, Croatia, Czechia, France, Germany, Hungary, Israel, Lithuania, Moldova, Netherlands, Poland, Romania, Serbia, Slovenia, Spain, Switzerland

Sweden (*de facto, but not formally*)

### 16 MC member countries not represented:

Belgium, Bosnia and Hercegovina, Cyprus, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, Greece, Ireland, Italy, Luxembourg Northern Macedonia, Montenegro, Norway, Portugal, Turkiye, United Kingdom

**The quorum is thus *not* fulfilled.**

## 2 OBJECTIVES

The Objectives of the MC III.1 meeting are:

- Provide accountability of CG
- Discuss the Evaluator's report
- Advise the CG on the further planning of budget and financial procedures
- Review network policies

## 3 AGENDA

### Welcome

#### State of the Network: Core Group Report to the MC

1. Membership
2. Activities
3. Financial situation
4. Emerging Issues

#### Evaluator's Report

#### Budget allocation & financial procedures

5. Relations with the GH
6. Grant lines
7. Other expenditure

#### Policy review

#### Any other business

## 4 WELCOME

The MC welcomes Peter Maurer, who will replace Henrik Örnebring as Swedish MC member.

## 5 STATE OF THE NETWORK: CORE GROUP REPORT

### Membership

OPINION has at present 216 members, and continues to grow. Membership applications are declining, at presently around three to four per month.

Since the last MC Meeting, OPINION has gained representation in Slovakia and Mexico (both new members already participated in the Lyon meeting). OPINION currently includes 38 out of 42 COST member/cooperating countries, lacking representation in Armenia, Bulgaria, Georgia and Iceland. Four more countries, namely Latvia, Malta, Slovakia, and Ukraine, currently lack representation on the MC.

Diversity remains high, with some clusters: Membership continues to be by a slight majority young, female, and based in ITC, consistent with inclusion objectives.

A growing concern has to do with our Turkish members: We already have relatively many Turkish members, and there is some evidence even of growing interest, but participation in meetings remains very low, obstructed primarily by visa. For every meeting so far, we have lost at least two to three Turkish members who had expressed interest in participating because it was impossible for them to secure visa. There is not much that we can do to help, as OPINION is not a legal entity and thus cannot issue invitation letters; the GH does not do so either, as it plausibly argues that it only administers our grant, and COST has repeatedly been unable to help, as well. We will raise the issue again with COST.

To mitigate the problem at least for the upcoming meeting, we have chosen a venue that does not require visa from Turkish members. However, this cannot be a long-term solution, as that would require COST networks to hold most meetings outside of the Schengen area - to the detriment of the majority of members.

### Financial situation

OPINION's budget for GP3 is currently similar to what we spent in GP2: A bit higher than our initial budget for GP2, a bit lower than our amended budget.

At the same time, demands for expenditure are systematically expanding on several fronts.

Interest in Joint WG Meetings is roughly stable, but there is a growing demand for WG-specific meetings (we hope to finance one for each WG in GP3).

Demand is growing notably for STSMs, and new expenses (notably for dissemination and publication/OA support) are becoming relevant.

To fully meet these needs, we will need an amended budget again, as in previous years. There is some planning uncertainty, as meetings never cost exactly as budgeted, and there is usually some money that can be shifted toward other events later in the GP, but current funds in GP3 do not suffice to fully meet all these growing demands. We currently plan optimistically with an amended budget, if that does not materialize, we will need to decide on what events to shrink or cut, or defer into GP4

## Activities

There have been several new network events since the last MC meeting:

- OPINION hosted a hackathon as a preconference at the ECREA European Communication Conference in Ljubljana, hosted by Felicia Loecherbach, Mariken van der Velden, and Johannes B. Gruber. There were 19 participants working together successfully in four diverse teams on very different projects.
- OPINION hosted a Special Panel at the ECREA European Communication Conference in Ljubljana, upon invitation by our member Ilija Tomanic Trivundza, hosted by Christian Baden & Helle Sjøvaag. There were four presentations in a packed room, and positive feedback from the community.
- OPINION has commenced a Webinar series, hosted by Elena Negrea Busuioc. A first installment featured two professional pollsters discussing public opinion research in the digital age.
- OPINION is preparing a Podcast series, hosted by Emese Domahidi, Mario Haim, and Wendo King'Ang'i. Initial episodes have been recorded and will be released soon.
- OPINION has funded 10 STSMs during GP2, with a total budget of about €19k. Grantees were Aleksandra Krstic, Ana Jovančević, Anna Baczowska, Asta Zelenkauskaitė, Cengiz Erisen, Edlira Gugu, Ljubisa Bojic, Nina Springer, and Roksana Gloc; most STSMs involved at least one ITC, and almost one in three involved a visit to VU Amsterdam, hosted by Damian Trilling, the undisputed most popular host.
- There was one 1 ICT Conference Grant, with a budget of about €1k, awarded to Ledia Kazazi.
- In GP3, there have already been 3 STSMs approved, with a total budget of €4k, granted to Barbara Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk, Christian Baden, and Mariken van der Velden.

## Emerging issues

A novel issue that has come to our attention is that some applicants, including some members, are also members of very many ongoing COST actions, in one case, more than 70. We find it questionable whether someone who is member of very many networks, often in quite different disciplines and fields, truly intends or is able to meaningfully contribute to all of these. At the same time, we have a few members who are members of several (up to five, six) current COST actions, but who have a proven track record of active and valuable contribution.

To handle the situation, we have begun to take the following measures:

For new applicants, we check whether they are members of other COST Actions. If applicants are already in five or more COST actions, that fact is flagged during the application evaluation stage, to be taken into consideration by the CG and especially the relevant WG leaderships. There is no automatic bias or even exclusion, but this information helps deciding on vague or generic applications, which could have been submitted in identical form to other actions.

For existing members, the WGs are in control of the prioritization process prior to upcoming meetings. Members who are members of many COST Actions are indicated, enabling WG leaderships to de-prioritize members from being invited if this seems appropriate given their contribution, or to fully uphold their priority for known active members. There is no prejudice about first-time attendees, but members of many networks who have attended in the past and did not perceptibly contribute will be de-prioritized for attendance.

*The MC supported the CG in this approach.*

## 6 EVALUATOR'S REPORT

We received an Evaluator's report on the first half of OPINION (the report was shared with members of the MC). The report expresses an overall strongly positive evaluation, but points out the need to keep focusing on outputs and deliverables.

Outputs have started to emerge, and accelerate rapidly, so we are not concerned about that.

Some deliverables have been of concern, but for different kinds of reasons. One challenge has to do with the difficulties in WG3, which could not operate well for a while owing to sickness of key members, and remarkably bad luck with travels to meetings. WG3 has eventually regrouped and has made good progress at the Lyon meeting, so we expect to bring the WG back on track. Other deliverables seem to make less sense than they did when we wrote the grant proposal: Given the rapid emergence of LLMs and generative AI, but also other relevant digital technologies (e.g., the METEOR repository), especially for the more technology-focused deliverables, there is an open question whether we should try to pursue them as originally foreseen, or redefine them in light of achieving similar capacities in a radically redefined technology context. There appears also to be some flexibility on part of COST in terms of the attainment of deliverables.

*The MC supported trying to adjust deliverables to what makes more sense given the recent technological changes, and explaining the need for adjustment.*

Other action items identified by the Evaluator's report include the need to advance and strengthen cross-WG communication & ensuring the coherence of outcomes across different WGs. In pursuit of this, the Lyon Joint WG meeting has already included some initiatives to facilitate cross-WG interactions.

*The MC supported further strengthening such initiatives, and also facilitating access to existing outputs (e.g., by "logging" outcomes on a specially dedicated channel on the Slack platform).*

Another item concerned the need to create outreach to non-academic stakeholders to actualize OPINION's impact beyond research. There are already several initiatives underway in this domain, notably, the webinar series, but also the upcoming manifesto prepared by WG1.

## 7 BUDGET ALLOCATION & FINANCIAL PROCEDURES

### Relations with the Grant Holding Institution, VU Amsterdam

There have been some irritations lately, resulting in major delays of some reimbursements, and some frustration both among us and our members, and among the VU financial team. Part of the reimbursement derive from the timing of the Salamanca meeting, shortly before the administrative holidays in the Netherlands; but others also have to do with inefficient processes (e.g., the VU used to take entries from the e-COST system manually over into their own system), staffing shortages (given the restructuring of financial resources and regulations in the Netherlands), and also a transition from our “regular” GM Aysen Simsek, who is on maternity leave, to our temporary GM, Aijan Kunnemann-Imanbaeva. The resulting situation was not ideal to the extent that the VU floated the possibility of dropping the Grant Holder role.

We strongly opposed this possibility, not only because of the massive disturbance that it would cause to shift the GH to another institution halfway through the action, but also because there aren’t really any realistic alternatives that make sense: The VU is a central institution in our network, and we don’t have other institutions with similar centrality and suitability that could take over.

As a compromise, we committed to facilitating data entry by asking our members to fill in their personal and bank data and reimbursement claims themselves into a separate digital form used by the VU financial services. The form takes simply the lump sum calculated by e-COST and enters that as travel expense into the VU’s financial administration system. This should not take more than 5 minutes for our members, and has the potential to considerably speed up the reimbursement process, so this seemed an acceptable compromise. There may be some transition pains though, as the form is new and may still generate bugs and unforeseen issues.

*The MC supported the CG in this decision, also given that we don’t really have much of a choice.*

### Grant Lines

COST has created a new line of mobility grants, called Young Researcher & Innovator Conference, which is exactly like ITC Conference Grants, only that eligibility is tied to being a YRI. The MC discussed whether we should accompany the current call for ITC Conference Grants with another one for YRI Conference Grants. The current WBP foresees €17k for STSMs and €5k for ITC Conference Grants (in GP2, we spent €19k and €1k, respectively).



*The MC supported the possibility of making conference grants available also to non-ITC members who qualify as YRI and can document a need for financial support. Grants should be handed out with an eye on need, not only formal eligibility: As many members formally qualify as YRI but are in fact relatively senior already, or have access to other sources of funding, YRI Conference Grants should be focused specifically on members who do not have other means of funding their attendance.*

## **Open Access support**

As outcomes start to be published, we need to design our strategy for awarding OA publishing support. As funds are scarce and OA costs can be very high, there is a need to prioritize.

The MC discussed different strategies. The MC leaned against partial funding for OA expenses, and in favor of a all-or-nothing approach, given that partial funding might still not enable authors to afford OA options. The MC discussed the possibility of focusing on minor expenses, so as to spread the funds wide, but also this option found little favor. The resonant argument was to focus on enabling OA publications that would otherwise be infeasible, but that add significant value to the network - even if these end up being expensive.

To mitigate costs, the MC discussed two strategies. One is to rely on the many institutional deals that exist between universities and publishers. Where author teams include authors whose institutions have suitable discount deals, OA costs can often be cut into fractions by the simple act of changing the corresponding author, or having the author at that institution handle the submission. The MC also stressed that such strategies must not come at the expense of reordering author sequences: If making use of discount deals would require less central authors at privileged institutions to become first authorship, the network should not incentivize such changes. The other, complementary strategy proposed is to ask authors to plan and apply well ahead, notifying the CG of upcoming publications, and thereby enabling everyone to systematically seek and evaluate options for reducing costs (by making use of discounts, identifying OA journals that do not charge, etc.). The CG will discuss and formalize such a strategy.

## 8 POLICY REVIEW

According to OPINION rules, the new GP triggers a review of current network policies.

### **Membership**

We discussed formalizing our policy about monitoring the number of ongoing COST networks that applicants are already members of, applying additional scrutiny to these applications.

*The MC found no need to formally adopt such a policy, as this form of application evaluation is already consistent with current procedures.*

### **Meetings**

*There was no motion to change the current policy.*

### **Reimbursement**

*There was no motion to change the current policy.*

### **Grants**

We discussed establishing two possible additional criteria for STSMs: giving explicit priority to STSMs that are fully within the network (members visit other members); and giving priority to STSMs that arise from ongoing project collaborations within the network.

*The MC found no need to formally adopt such a policy, as this form of application evaluation is already consistent with current procedures, and might unduly narrow the capacity of the Grants Coordination Team to evaluate applications.*

### **Publications**

We discussed bringing our policy on what publications to formally adopt as outcomes of the network back into line with the updated COST criteria for eligibility for OA support. Current COST rules are slightly stricter: We require authors at three different institutions, COST requires three different countries, which must be member countries (one can be NNC).

*The MC decided to not change our policy, in light of ongoing projects that might have developed in awareness of our current policy, and whom we might otherwise disenfranchise.*

## Communications

*There was no motion to change the current policy.*

## Review

*There was no motion to change the current policy.*

## 9 ANY OTHER BUSINESS

None